

## CHAPTER TWO

### THE SACRED WATERS

Water is essential for life, and it has therefore universally been attributed the highest importance and religious significance. In a religious context, water takes on many different aspects, some of which may at first seem contradictory, as the creative and destructive associations of water. Such ambiguities, however, are also typical of certain gods, and can generally be seen as a common characteristic of the sacred which may never be fully understood.<sup>1</sup> Because a detailed analysis and discussion of the religious significance and various usages of water in South Asia would be a thesis in itself, in this short religious introduction, many aspects will have to be dealt with very briefly. Emphasis will be placed on those aspects of water which are necessary for the understanding of the water structures in the following chapters, and the rituals and sculptures associated with them.

#### I. WATER AND THE CREATION OF THE WORLD

In most South Asian cosmogonies, the myths which tell how in primordial times the world came into existence, water (*āpaḥ*) predates all creation. Through its fluidity and elusiveness, it is a symbol of chaos and the absence of form. The waters are the primordial substance from which creation emanates and to which it returns at the end of a cosmic cycle. Because the waters are the essence of life, they are regarded as divine. Water, as the source of creation, is frequently said to contain a divine seed or germ. In certain stories, the emergence of the first primordial matter within the water is described as resulting from an autonomous process of coagulation, or the creation of ascetic heat (*tapas*) or desire, which condenses this matter. The cosmic germ is frequently described as an egg, the *hiranyagarbha*,<sup>2</sup> which contains the world in potential, but at the same time is the world itself. Also in the present fully created world, water still possesses certain qualities attributed to it in the cosmogonies. For example all water, and particularly that of rivers, is regarded as generative and life-giving, similar to the creative power of the cosmic ocean.

In other cosmogonies, a god is said to have intervened in the process of creation, as for instance Viṣṇu as Varāha, who in the form of a boar dives into the waters and brings up the first clod of earth from the bottom of the cosmic ocean. In some versions, the clod of earth is given human form as Bhū Devī, the goddess of the earth. A panel depicting this part of the creation story may be seen in the cave temple number five at Udayagiri in Madhya Pradesh. While in some stories a lotus is said to grow from the clod of earth, in others it is placed on top of a lotus leaf which is upheld and supported by the cosmic waters. An interesting parallel to this story is the

<sup>1</sup> Rudhardt in M. Eliade, 1987(a), *The Encyclopedia of Religion*, vol. 15, p. 357.

<sup>2</sup> F. D. K. Bosch, 1994, *The Golden Germ: An Introduction to Indian Symbolism*, p. 53.

small lotus shaped platform in the centre of the Kumāra Pokuna at Polonnaruva (Polonnaruvā) in Sri Lanka (Plate 190). This first stage of the various cosmogonies represents still an undifferentiated unity which arises from and floats on the cosmic waters.

In the subsequent step of the cosmogony, the first matter or undifferentiated unity has to be fixed to provide a place of reference, a sacred centre, which has to be opened up to reveal and release creation. The original whole has to be divided into the multiplicity of the phenomenal world. In cosmogonic literature, this stage is frequently related to the slaying of a dragon (Vṛtra) or cosmic man (*puruṣa*), who is sacrificed to provide the substance for a new creation of life and the cosmos. Several of these stories are related to the god Indra, who slays the dragon or snake and breaks open the primordial hill to create the world. With the peg (*Indra-kīla*), with which Indra kills the dragon, he also fixes the mountain, situated at the centre of the world. The idea that creation is the division of a divine integral unity into the multiplicity of existence is also essential to the belief that the divine is within every object in the world. In the following part of the creation, Indra props up the sky and creates the first duality of heaven and earth. This stage is frequently associated with images such as a pillar, the tree of life, the thunderbolt (*vajra*), the rising sun, or a mountain which represent the *axis mundi*.

Related to the dismemberment of the cosmic unity, which is needed to supply the material for a subsequent creation, is a widespread belief in South Asia, that a constant supply of water and as such the effectiveness of a water structure, is secured most efficiently by a sacrifice. Regarded as most potent and propitiating towards water divinities is a human sacrifice, which guarantees durability and efficacy to the building.<sup>3</sup> The *Rgveda*, the *Yajurveda* and the *Aitareya Brāhmaṇa* describe human sacrifices (*puruṣamedha*) as strengthening for structures,<sup>4</sup> and a legend describes how through a human sacrifice the Sahasra Liṅga Tank at Patan, Gujarat, which had dried up through the power of a curse, was resupplied with water.<sup>5</sup> Especially for Gujarat, there are many reports of self-sacrifices as part of the consecration of water monuments. The victims had to be buried in the foundation of the water structures, and archaeological excavations in the so-called Great Tank at Vijayanagara revealed a vaulted chamber under the floor containing the human remains of a man who is believed to have been sacrificed during the consecration of the tank.<sup>6</sup> Nowadays, such sacrifices are replaced by offerings of food and coconuts.

There are ample architectural examples, which will be discussed in detail particularly in Chapter Four, on 'Tanks', which give material shape to the stages of the cosmogony so far discussed. Pillars, similar to Indra's peg at the creation of the world, are frequently found at the centre of tanks and reservoirs and mark the sacred spot of creation. It is also at the centre of the

<sup>3</sup> J. Jain-Neubauer, 1981, *The Stepwells of Gujarat in Art-Historical Perspective*, pp. 6, 8.

<sup>4</sup> Ibid., p. 8. Although folk mythologies and legends, particularly in Gujarat, report on human sacrifices, there are not many reports on the actual execution of such rites in earlier texts. It seems, however, to have been practice to slay the first-born sons of kings during the rite of *rājasūya*, the royal consecration of a king. The end to this practice is described in the *Aitareya Brāhmaṇa* VII.13–16 dealing with Śunaḥśepa who is saved from being sacrificed (A. B. Keith, 1920, *Rigveda Brahmanas: The Aitareya and Kauṣītiki Brāhmaṇas of the Rigveda*, pp. 61, 62).

<sup>5</sup> Jain-Neubauer, 1981, p. 8.

<sup>6</sup> Archaeological Survey of India, Annual Report 1904–5, p. 30, Archaeological Survey of Madras and Coorg, Annual Progress Report 1904–5, p. 36.

cosmos or the earth that the reunion with the ultimate unity from which all resolves can be found again. The centre represents a kind of 'gate' through which transcendence and liberation can be gained. Therefore, temples and pavilions have frequently been constructed in the centre of tanks or lakes. They represent the cosmic unity and are a material manifestation of the divine energy contained within the waters. Like the first seed or mountain, the buildings seem to have arisen from the water on which they appear to float. Other temples were set on islands where they can be reached by causeways which provide access to the cosmic centre. Here, the visit to the temple is not only spiritually but also materially a clear expression of a return to the centre and the creation of the world. Mircea Eliade describes this tendency as man's desire periodically to return to his origin.<sup>7</sup> Also the idea that the multiplicity of creation develops out of the cosmic water has frequently been given architectural shape by many, sometimes hundreds, of *liṅgas*, the phallic emblem of god Śiva, and shrines surrounding water reservoirs.

In a different set of traditions it is Viṣṇu who as Nārāyaṇa reclines, supported by a lotus or the coiled serpent Śeṣa or Ananta, on the cosmic waters. The Kathmandu Valley has three large-scale sculptures placed in water tanks which depict this part of the myth (Plate 1). A sculptural panel depicting this scene may also be seen in the Mahiṣamardinī Cave Temple at Mamallapuram (Māmallapuram, Mahābalipuram) in Tamil Nadu. Frequently, a lotus is depicted growing from Nārāyaṇa's navel, which can be equated with the centre of the universe. The unfolding lotus reveals Brahmā within and unleashes creation. Carved panels associated with this story are frequently found in connection with water structures. Small versions of sculptures set into miniature basins may be seen at the *ghāṭs* in Benares, and along most rivers in Nepal (Plate 54). A beautifully carved panel was integrated into the side of the Koṭī Tirtha in Kalinjar Fort (Kālāñjara) in Madhya Pradesh, and a similar panel is contained within the central shrine on the eastern side of the *kuṇḍa* at Modhera. Viṣṇu Nārāyaṇa is also the main sacred image of the Rāñī Vāv at Patan, one of the largest and most elaborate stepwells.

In the created world, water plays an important role as an ordering principle. The dividing of the waters defines cosmic order and at the end of a cosmic cycle reabsorbs creation again into nothingness.<sup>8</sup> In the periodical reabsorption, all is dissolved, purified and enriched with new possibilities. This reflects the cyclic world view, particularly of the Hindus, which is well expressed by the image of Viṣṇu Nārāyaṇa, who floats asleep on the cosmic ocean and whose awakening marks the beginning of a new world era, a *kalpa*. Since long before the connection between the lunar phases and water was scientifically proven, in South Asia water was associated with and even assimilated to the moon. The *Chāṇḍogya Upaniṣad* and the *Brāhmaṇas*, regularly identify the moon with *soma*<sup>9</sup> which in turn is associated with *amṛta*, the elixir of life and immortality created by the *devas* and the *asuras* during the churning of the Milky Ocean. This story again expresses the belief in a divine substance as contained within the waters, which can be concen-

<sup>7</sup> M. Eliade, 1991(a), *The Myth of the Eternal Return*, pp. 17–18.

<sup>8</sup> The connection between water and law or order is sometimes hinted at in the names given to water structures, as for example in the Dharma Kūpa at Benares.

<sup>9</sup> *Chāṇḍogya Upaniṣad* V.10.4, *Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa* II.4.2 and 7, and *Aitareya Brāhmaṇa* I.7.11 (32.10). For a discussion of further references in other *Brāhmaṇas* and the *Vedas*, see A. B. Keith, 1925, *The Religion and Philosophy of the Vedas and Upanishads*, p. 170.

trated and abstracted, such as the divine seed or egg. Depictions of the churning of the ocean are not only common to the Hindu context, but also adorn Sikh shrines.<sup>10</sup> Water in general is a symbol of life and represents a combination of aspects of fertility, health and immortality.

## 2. HOLY RIVERS

### *Rivers as Divine Mothers*

Rivers are regarded as divine because water is the essence of life, and because earthly rivers are believed to originate in heaven. They are regarded as the continuation of heavenly waters on earth, and as the offspring of the gods. Brahmaputra, for example, means the 'Son of Brahmā'.<sup>11</sup> Most rivers, however, are feminine, and in the stories connected with rivers, they are often associated with earthly women. One such story is known about the river Kaveri (Kāverī), who is said to have been the wife of the sage Agastya. Because one day Agastya did not return home, Kāverī threw herself into a tank, sank to the bottom and disappeared underground. She became the river Kaveri and reappeared as a spring on top of Brahmagiri (Brahmāgiri), a nearby hill.<sup>12</sup> Because rivers are generally worshipped as goddesses, the rituals and offerings made to female deities or human women are also appropriate for rivers.<sup>13</sup> Sculptures and temples of river goddesses will be discussed in the section on 'Water Divinities', later on in this chapter.

Not only are rivers worshipped in the form of anthropomorphic images of river goddesses; Hindus also pay reverence to the physical rivers themselves. Certain rivers, particularly the sacred Ganges, are circumambulated by pilgrims who start at the source, walk along one side of the river until they meet its mouth, and then walk back on the other side. Some pilgrims prostrate themselves, measuring the entire way with the length of their bodies. To circumambulate the Ganges in this way takes about six years.<sup>14</sup> Devotees may also worship rivers by stringing garlands of flowers often hundreds of metres long, across their width.<sup>15</sup> Rivers are thus adorned in the same way as temple images, and food, coconuts and flowers are also offered to them (Plate 3). In the evenings, devotees set small boats made of leaves filled with flowers and lights afloat on rivers and tanks to worship the sacred waters and to adorn and entertain the river goddesses. The earliest dated accounts of the worship and deification of the Ganges date from Megasthenes, who arrived as ambassador at the Mauryan court in 302 BC.<sup>16</sup>

Rivers are not only regarded as goddesses, but also as divine mothers, a connection made already in the *Rgveda*.<sup>17</sup> This association is based on the fact that rivers flow through the land-

<sup>10</sup> A Sikh example of a panel depicting the churning of the cosmic ocean adorns the Bābā Atal Tower in Amritsar (Amṛtsarovar) in Punjab.

<sup>11</sup> In Tibet, the Brahmaputra is called the Tsang-Po meaning 'The Purifier'.

<sup>12</sup> A. Valliappa, 1992, *The Story of Our Rivers: Part II*, pp. 10–11.

<sup>13</sup> A. Feldhaus, 1995, *Water & Womanhood: Religious Meanings of Rivers in Maharashtra*, p. 43.

<sup>14</sup> D. Eck, 1993, *Banaras: City of Light*, p. 212; Newby in R. Singh & E. Newby, 1974, *Ganges: Sacred River of India*, pp. 16–17.

<sup>15</sup> D. Kinsley, 1987, *Hindu Goddess: Visions of the Divine Feminine in the Hindu Religious Tradition*, p. 196.

<sup>16</sup> J. Mahajan, 1984, *The Ganga Trail: Foreign Accounts and Sketches of the River Scene*, p. 11.

<sup>17</sup> See RV I.34.8 and RV III.33.3.

scape, watering plants and fields. The land bordering them can be intensely cultivated because of the fertile sediments deposited by the periodic floods and the continuous availability of water for irrigation. The rivers are thus seen to fertilise the country and nourish the people in the way a mother does.<sup>18</sup> Hence river water has frequently been likened to milk, the milk of a mother or a cow, and also to *amṛta*.<sup>19</sup>

Rivers are venerated not only to ensure good crops but also to promote fertility in women.<sup>20</sup> Women who want offspring may bathe in rivers or certain tanks which are particularly renowned for their fertile properties. One such tank, which is visited by childless couples, is situated in the second enclosure of the Temple at Tiruvellarai in Tamil Nadu, but stepwells in general are visited by brides or young couples after their wedding, to gain fertility and healthy offspring. As part of fertility rites, seeds are thrown into rivers, and pots with sprouting grains are deposited in stepwells which are frequently associated with mother goddesses. In the Yoginī Temple at Khajuraho, women offer clay water pots filled with grain to the goddesses to ensure their own fertility and a good crop. Because of the fertility aspect of water, it is also common to the entire subcontinent to find depictions of *mithuna* couples carved into the sides of water structures, as may be seen in the Bhīm Lāt Kuṇḍa at Chitorgarh, the Moḍherā Kuṇḍa, and the *kuṇḍa* at Kamalapuram (Kamalapurā) in Karnataka. Carved images of the tantric goddess Lajjā Gaurī may also be associated with water structures, like the *kuṇḍa* of the Śrī Yogānandīśvara Svāmī Temple in Nandi Fort and the tank of the Huchimalligudi at Aihole,<sup>21</sup> both in Karnataka. Images of mother goddesses, the *saptamātṛkas* and the *aṣṭamātṛkas* are also common.

There is a close relationship between the feminine waters or rivers, and Śiva's masculine *liṅga*. Water or milk, which are both considered ritually cooling substances, are poured over *liṅgas* as part of worship (Plate 57), and clay or brass pots from whose base water drips continuously are suspended above *śiva-liṅgas* in the *garbhagrha* of temples. This practice is related to the story of the descent of the Ganges, which poured from heaven onto Śiva's hair or head. At Sahasradha (Sahasrādhā) near Dehra Dun (Dehrādūn) in Uttar Pradesh, a *liṅga* contained in a natural cave from whose ceiling water drips constantly is an important object of worship. It is also common practice, particularly at the beaches on Gangasagar Dvīp (Gaṅgāsāgara Dvīp) in West Bengal, where the Ganges enters the Bay of Bengal, and at Rameshvaram (Rāmeśvaram) in Tamil Nadu, where Sītā is said to have done so, to form *liṅgas* out of sand which are lustrated and dissolved by the rising tides. More permanent expressions of the same idea may be seen along the bank of the Tungabhadra River at Vijayanagara, where *liṅgas* and other religious images were carved into the boulders bordering the river.<sup>22</sup> Depressions around the *liṅgas* keep them encircled by water even when the river recedes; post holes surrounding some of the carvings hint at the possibility of

<sup>18</sup> Feldhaus, 1995, p. 82; Kinsley, 1987, p. 194.

<sup>19</sup> This led to the naming of certain tanks as pools of immortality, as the Amṛt Sarovar in the hill-top fort at Nandi in Karnataka, and the better known tank of the same name at Amṛtsar (Amṛtsarovar) in the Punjab.

<sup>20</sup> Kinsley, 1987, p. 194.

<sup>21</sup> For a photograph of the 8th–9th century depiction from Aihole, see C. Radcliffe Bolon, 1992, *Forms of the Goddess Lajjā Gaurī in Indian Art*, fig. 109.

<sup>22</sup> J. A. Patt describes similar carvings of *liṅgas* along a river near Angkor in Cambodia (1979, "The Use and Symbolism of Water in Ancient Indonesian Art and Architecture", PhD dissertation, pp. 38–39).

setting up temporary structures such as awnings or small shrines above them. Many *ghāts* in India and Nepal are lined by stone *lingas*, which at high water level are bathed and submerged by the rivers, which purify them and imbue them with divine energy.

### *Rivers and Cows*

There is a strong association of water in general, and of rivers in particular, with cows and their bodily products. Cows are powerful maternal images, and this aspect links up well with the idea of rivers as being female and regarded as mothers. Cows are holy, and like the sacred waters are regarded as symbols of wealth, prosperity and fertility. Already during the Vedic age, rivers were likened to cows,<sup>23</sup> the rising of their water level was compared to the swelling of the udders of cows,<sup>24</sup> and their waters were regarded as milk.<sup>25</sup> The association of water and cows is regularly expressed in water-related architecture, and cows play an important part in the consecration rituals of water structures. During the consecration ceremony of a tank, a cow should be covered and brought into the water of the newly built structure to make its waters sacred. In the case of a well, the cow is led around the structure, but even the presence of a cow is believed to bestow sacredness on the monument and the water it contains.<sup>26</sup>

The connection between rivers and cows is particularly obvious in the case of the river Godavari. Folk etymologies divide its short form 'Godā' into the parts 'Go', meaning 'cow', and 'dā', 'to give'.<sup>27</sup> According to the *Godāvarī Māhātmya*, the story of the Godavari which also deals with the descent of the Ganges, the Godavari was brought down from heaven because the sage Gotama killed a cow.<sup>28</sup> Small brass images of cows together with money are offered to the goddess Godāvarī at the source of the river and at a tank further down Brahmagiri (Brahmāgiri) at Trimbak (Trymbakeśvara) in Maharashtra. The Godavari has often been identified with the Ganges, whose physical source, near Gangotri (Gaṅgotrī) in Uttar Pradesh, is called Gomukh (Gomukha) or Gaymukh (Gāymukha), meaning 'cow head' or 'cow mouth'. The glacier out of which the Ganges issues is believed to be in the form of a cow's head, and the *Gaṅgā Māhātmya* provides detailed information on its shape. According to this text, the Ganges fell from heaven onto Mount Meru where it divided into four streams emerging from four rocks in the shape of animal heads. The earthly Ganges issued out of a cow head, the Chaksu out of a horse head, the Sita out of an elephant head and the Bhadrāsoma out of a lion head.<sup>29</sup> The lesser known Nira River in Maharashtra issues at its source from a sculpted stone cow's head before it collects in a small tank in front, and at the source of the Narmada, at Amarkantak (Amarkaṇṭaka) in Madhya Pradesh, the river water is channelled through a *gomukh* spout. In the Pañcagaṅgā Temple (Five Gaṅgā or Five River Temple) at Mahabaleshvar (Mahābaleśvara) in Maharashtra, where the

<sup>23</sup> RV I.32.3 and 11, RV III.3.1, RV V.53.7.

<sup>24</sup> RV III.33.12, RV III.33.4.

<sup>25</sup> RV I.104.3 and 4, RV I.130.5, RV II.13.2, RV III.33.1, RV VII.36.6.

<sup>26</sup> P. V. Kane, 1974, *History of Dharmaśāstra: Ancient and Medieval Religious Law*, p. 890; Jain-Neubauer, 1981, pp. 5, 8.

<sup>27</sup> Feldhaus, 1995, p. 46.

<sup>28</sup> *Ibid.*, p. 46.

<sup>29</sup> S. Piano, 1990, *Il Mito del Gange—Gaṅgā Māhātmya*, p. 26.



Krishna, the Koyna, the Vena, the Gayatri and the Savitri Rivers are believed to originate in separate shrines, the waters of the five rivers are channelled through the body of a small stone cow and issue from its mouth into a tank in the temple compound.<sup>30</sup> Frequently, rivers are believed to flow for considerable distances underground, and to reappear in temples or tanks not obviously connected with the sacred rivers.<sup>31</sup> At such places, cow heads are often employed to hint at the origin of the waters and to identify them as sacred river waters. An example of this is one of the twin tanks below the source of the Godavari on Brahmagiri at Trimbak. The water in the small tank issues out of the mouth of a stone cow head and an inscription above reads 'Śrī Gaṅgā-Godāvarī Prasan[n]', meaning 'clear' or 'pure auspicious Gaṅgā-Godāvarī'. This stresses also again the close relationship between the Ganges and the Godavari. The headless torso belonging to the *gomukh* spout in the tank is found on top of Brahmagiri at the actual source of the river.<sup>32</sup>

There are many examples where cow head spouts were installed in tanks without any connection with an actual river. Tanks containing cow imagery are, however, usually sacred pilgrimage spots, where the presence of a cow sculpture symbolises the purity and sacredness of the water. Examples may be seen at Siddhpur (Siddhapurā) in Gujarat, where there are two examples of *gomukh* spouts in the Alpa Sarovar, and at Adavad in Maharashtra, where the naturally hot water of the Unabdev spring issues out of the mouth of a cow. The cow head is painted red, indicating its holiness, and flower garlands are placed on its head in reverence. Such spouts are also associated with most other types of water architecture. They are for example to be seen in the *kuṇḍa* at Ghanerao (Ghānerāv) and in the Gomukh Kuṇḍa near Mount Abu (Ābū Parvat) (Plate 47), both in Rajasthan. In connection with the water troughs of wells, *gomukh* spouts are especially common in the region around Amaravati (Amarāvati) in Maharashtra, whilst an example of a such a spout contained in a stepwell is located in the village of Ranakpur (Rānakpur) in Rajasthan. Temple *pranālīs*, the channels through which passes the mixture of milk, ghee and water poured over the *liṅga* in the *garbhagrha* of a temple—usually out of the northern side of the *vimāna* or *prāsāda*—may also be in the shape of cow heads. This is the case with the *pranālīs* of the Gṛśneśvara Temple<sup>33</sup> in Ellora (Ellorā, Elūrā) village,<sup>34</sup> the Siddheśvara Temple in Sholapur (Śolāpur), the last two both in Maharashtra, and the Pandhra Śivālaya in Pashupatinath (Paśu-patinātha, Devpātan) in Nepal.

The use of cow imagery indicates the sacredness and purity, but also the cleansing properties of the liquid. The connection between sacred waters and cow heads is also continued in modern

<sup>30</sup> In a further niche in the northern wall of the temple, the sacred Ganges is said to occur one year in twelve, and the Sarasvati River is believed to issue out of a seventh niche for one week every six years (Feldhaus, 1995, p. 21).

<sup>31</sup> This perception becomes particularly clear in the *Purāṇas* (see for example S. M. Ali, 1973, "The River System of the Puranas", in his book *The Geography of the Puranas*, p. 60), and it is also a belief which is very alive in Nepal, where all water structures are believed to be connected underground. In Islam, too, where paradise is imagined as "a garden beneath which rivers flow", the idea of underground rivers is re-encountered (Schimmel in A. Petruccioli, 1985, *Water and Architecture*, p. 6).

<sup>32</sup> Feldhaus, 1995, 46.

<sup>33</sup> For this temple name various spellings exist. A further common way of spelling it is Gṛśneśvara.

<sup>34</sup> Locally, the caves at Ellora are known as Verula Lenī.

structures, as for example the large twentieth-century cow head spout at the bathing *ghāṭs* of the Mallikārjuna Temple at Srisaīlam (Śrīsaīlam) in Andhra Pradesh, and in a modern fountain at Trimbak. In the latter, the water issues out of four cow heads which are fixed to a central pillar carrying a sculpture of Śiva wearing a tiger skin. In comparison with the frequent occurrence of cow heads in water architecture, sculptures of entire cows are relatively rare; they are, however, found at Mahabaleshvar and on Brahmagiri at Trimbak, mentioned above.

Various river *māhātmyas* identify certain rivers with bodily products of cows. The *Bhīmā Māhātmya*, for example, associates the Narmada River with the urine of a cow and the Yamuna with cow dung.<sup>35</sup> Every twelve years, the Sipra River is believed to turn into milk,<sup>36</sup> the name of the Payoshni River in Maharashtra means 'warm milk',<sup>37</sup> and one of the many names attributed to the Ganges is *Kṣīrā-śubha*, 'white as milk'.<sup>38</sup> Not only rivers but also tanks, *kuṇḍas* and wells are at times associated with milk. A stream of milk is for example frequently reported to spout out of the water surface of the large reservoir called the *Mānsīgaṅgā* (*Mānasa Gaṅgā*) at Govardhan (Govardhana) in Uttar Pradesh.<sup>39</sup> Cows and all their bodily products are considered particularly purifying and are frequently used in rituals.

### *The Sacred Ganges*

The Ganges is considered the purest and most sacred of South Asia's rivers, and is the prototype of all sacred waters.<sup>40</sup> Large numbers of pilgrims come to the Ganges for a purifying bath, if possible at a particularly sacred spot such as Hardwar (Haridvāra, Māyāpurī) or Benares, both in Uttar Pradesh (Plate 2), and it is the wish of devout Hindus to be cremated on the banks of the sacred river and to have their ashes scattered in it. The Ganges has been personified in the anthropomorphic image of Gaṅgā Devī, the Goddess Gaṅgā, who is depicted standing on her vehicle, the *makara*, a mythical sea animal, holding a lotus or a plate of food in one hand, and a water pot in the other. Being depicted with nurturing and overflowing symbols, a strong element of her worship is the reverence of her maternal aspects. She is commonly known as Gaṅgā Mātā, Mother Ganges, and her worship is not restricted to the north, the region in which the Ganges flows, but encountered all over India, Nepal, and Sri Lanka.

Rivers in other parts of India are also associated with the Ganges. The Kaveri is commonly referred to as the Ganges of the south, and the Godavari is considered part of the Ganges, diverted to central India.<sup>41</sup> There are innumerable rivers called Ramaganga, Krishnaganga or Vishnuganga and the main river to the east of Polunaruva, Sri Lanka, is called the Mahaweliganga, formerly

<sup>35</sup> *Bhīmā Māhātmya* 8.23 and 8.29 respectively.

<sup>36</sup> P. Dubey, 1992, *The Maha Kumbh at Prayag*, p. 13.

<sup>37</sup> Feldhaus, 1995, p. 47.

<sup>38</sup> Newby in Singh & Newby, 1974, p. 19.

<sup>39</sup> D. Anand, 1992, *Krishna: The Living God of Braj*, p. 55.

<sup>40</sup> Although the belief in the purity of the Ganges developed out of spiritual concepts and religious thought, scientific studies have sought to prove the dirt and bacteria absorbing abilities of the Ganges (Dubey, 1992, p. 12; N. Gutschow & A. Michaels, 1993, *Benares: Tempel und religiöses Leben in der heiligen Stadt der Hindus*, p. 50).

<sup>41</sup> Eck, 1993, p. 214.



known as the Maha Ganga or the Mahavaluka Ganga.<sup>42</sup> Through their names and mythology, other rivers were related to the sacredness of the Ganges. This is also based on the Purāṇic perception that the descent of the Ganges consists of three distinct stages. It originates in heaven where the Ganges is equated to the Milky Way, descending to earth in the shape of snow covering the mountains of the subcontinent; the 'snowy' or 'glacial' stage is followed by the earthly fluvial Ganges coming from the snow of the hills. According to the *Purāṇas*, every river which springs from snow-covered mountains is regarded as a manifestation of the sacred Ganges.<sup>43</sup> Today, the Ganges is symbolically believed to flow within every river, and also the water of a tank or even that contained in a pot may be regarded as, or ritually transformed into, Ganges water by evoking the presence of Gaṅgā Devī.<sup>44</sup> As part of consecration rites, Ganges water is frequently poured into water structures in order to sanctify their waters.<sup>45</sup>

The Ganges itself is known under innumerable names. The part closest to its source at the Gomukh Glacier is called Bhagirathi, because it was at this place that the sage Bhagīratha caused the Ganges to descend from heaven through austere penance. There are many stories concerning the descent of the heavenly river to earth, but probably the best known is that connected with Bhagīratha. According to the myths, the sage Kapila was disturbed in his meditation by the sixty thousand sons of King Sāgara and out of anger burned them to ashes. None of the king's pious descendants managed to restore their forefathers, until generations later, Bhagīratha persuaded the river Ganges, who flowing in heaven is called Mandākinī or Svargāṅgā,<sup>46</sup> to descend to earth to dissolve the ashes of his ancestors. Because her fall from heaven would have destroyed the earth, Śiva agreed to receive the Ganges on his head, where, diverted in his hair, the Ganges split into four or seven rivers, depending on the textual source.<sup>47</sup> The mention of seven sacred rivers, the Indus, the Sarasvati, and the five rivers of Punjab, is as old as the *Ṛgveda*.<sup>48</sup> The main river, the sacred Ganges, washed away and dissolved the ashes of the king's sons and they were thereby purified and saved. This happened at Gangasagar, where the Ganges, called the Hoogly, enters the Bay of Bengal. In some versions, the Ganges is said to have entered the underworld to free the king's sons, an idea which contributes to her name Triloka-patha-gaminī, the 'triple-pathed-river', or 'she who flows in the three worlds'.<sup>49</sup> There are many other myths concerned with the origin of

<sup>42</sup> R. L. Brohier, 1965, *Seeing Ceylon*, p. 47.

<sup>43</sup> Ali, 1973, pp. 63–64, 68.

<sup>44</sup> Many tanks were given the name Gaṅgā such as the Gaṅgā Sāgar tank in Raigarh (Raigarh) in Maharashtra, or the Mānsi Gaṅgā Tank at Govardhan.

<sup>45</sup> This was done for example when the large tank near the temple at Gangaikondacholapuram (Gaṅgaikondacholapuram) in Tamil Nadu was dedicated to the public by Rājendra Coja (Patt, 1979, p. 28).

<sup>46</sup> Mandākinī is associated with the Milky Way (Pant in A. Dilwali & P. Pant, 1987, *Ganga: Origin and Descent of the River Eternal*, p. 1), and there is also an actual river called Mandakini, on the banks of which the Kedārmātha Temple at Kedarnath (Kedārmātha) in Uttar Pradesh is located. The river originates in Cobārī Tāl, a lake nearby, in which some of the ashes of Mahātmā Gāndhī were immersed; this led to it being renamed Gāndhī Sarovar.

<sup>47</sup> Today, the seven heavenly rivers are considered to be the Ganges, the Yamuna, the Godavari, the Sarasvati, the Narmada, the Indus and the Kaveri (Bonn in P. Frey & G. Bonn, 1991, *Ganges*, p. 28).

<sup>48</sup> RV I.32.12, RV I.35.8, RV II.12.12, RV IV.28.1, RV VIII.41.2, RV X.13.5, RV X.104.8.

<sup>49</sup> Kinsley, 1987, p. 192; Eck, 1993, p. 211. In heaven she is connected with the Milky Way; on earth she is the sacred river Ganges; flowing in the netherworld she can surface at any sacred place (Bonn in Frey & Bonn, 1991, p. 154.).

the divine river. Some relate to Viṣṇu, who with his foot made a hole into the vault of heaven through which the heavenly river poured, others to Brahmā, who is believed to have kept the Ganges in a water pot. All stories account for the divine nature, purity, and ability of the Ganges to wash away sins and bestow salvation (*mokṣa*) on the dead.

The various versions of the story of the mythical descent of the Ganges encouraged countless paintings and sculptural representations. Gaṅgādhara-mūrtis, for example, depict Śiva receiving the river goddess Gaṅgā in his hair. In several seated sculptures of Śiva, located at the centre of water reservoirs in the Kathmandu Valley (*pokharis*) and in a modern fountain in the Kālahastīśvara Temple in Kalahasti (Kālahasti, Kālāhastī) in Andhra Pradesh, the water issues from the top of Śiva's head, and makes direct reference to the descent of the Ganges. On top of Brahmagiri at Trimbak, a small temple was constructed over a ribbed section of the rocky mountain, which is referred to as Śiva's hair (*jaṭā*), and the water which collects at the lowest point of the rock is regarded as Ganges water.<sup>50</sup> Probably the largest depictions dedicated to the theme of the descent of the Ganges, are two seventh-century reliefs cut into natural boulders at Mamallapuram. In the larger and better known composition, next to the Pañca Pāṇḍava Maṇḍapa, water was stored in a tank on top of the rocks, and could be released to pour down in the narrow cleft between the two boulders. The carvings between the rocks depict water-related beings such as snakes and water birds, and show Bhagīratha involved in austerities. Alternatively, the composition can be read as a depiction of Arjuna's penance.

Although the Ganges has this particular importance only for Hindus, the members of other religions pay tribute to the river and have integrated it into their legends. The fourteenth century traveller Ibn Baṭṭūṭa was the first to report that Ganges water was also drunk and considered special by Muslims, and that Delhi sultans and noble men exclusively drank *gaṅgājal* (Ganges water).<sup>51</sup> According to Abū'l Faz'l, Akbar was one of them, and Ganges water had to be taken on his military campaigns.<sup>52</sup> Even the pious and orthodox Aurangzeb (Ālamgīr) is said to have preferred water from the Ganges to any other.<sup>53</sup> Many Buddhists believe that the Ganges originates at the foot of Mount Kailāsa or in Lake Mānasarovar, two water places sacred to the Buddhists.

### 3. TĪRTHAS

#### *Tīrthas and Pilgrimage*

Sacred sites in India, Nepal and Sri Lanka are commonly connected with geographical or natural peculiarities. They are believed to possess supernatural powers, and to be locations where contact with the divine is more likely. Such places are frequently located on hill tops, where one is nearer to heaven and the purer realms of the gods, or they may be rock caves, large trees or water-related sites, such as rivers, confluences or lakes. Other places are sanctified through local legends and

<sup>50</sup> Felhaus, 1995, p. 26.

<sup>51</sup> Mahajan, 1984, pp. 24–25.

<sup>52</sup> Pant in Dilwali & Pant, 1987, p. 2.

<sup>53</sup> Dubey, 1992, p. 12.

mythology, by relating stories about the deeds and lives of gods, goddesses and sages to actual geographical places. In these last cases, however, it has to be assumed that the sites have long been sacred places of worship, and that their 'rediscovery' has to do with the reintegration or reappropriation of ancient places of worship to new or changing beliefs.<sup>54</sup> The places themselves are the primary object of worship, and the names of the gods and the legends connected with them have changed over the centuries. Hence the religious affiliation of sacred places can change, and followers of different faiths may worship at a common place.

In the wider Hindu tradition, sacred places are called *tīrthas*. A *tīrtha* is a 'ford' or a 'crossing place', which has been sanctified by an encounter, a hierophany,<sup>55</sup> with divine powers. At such places, gods are believed to have descended to earth, and to have broken open and established a threshold or door to descend to earth which can also be used by human beings to ascend to heaven. They are sites where contact with the divine is more easily established, and where salvation may be reached. As such, they are places of transition and change. The verb *tī/tarati* means 'to cross over', 'to ford', and therefore the term *tīrtha* is particularly closely connected with water or bathing places.<sup>56</sup> A. W. Entwistle remarks that in the more recent vernacular texts dealing with pilgrimage and sacred places in Braj, the older term *tīrtha* is usually replaced by *ghāṭ* or *kuṇḍa*, which are terms for different types of water structures.<sup>57</sup> The *ghāṭs* at Benares were originally referred to as *tīrthas*, and in the south of India, the term *tīrtha* has come to mean 'sacred water' in general.<sup>58</sup>

To use the metaphor of fording a river or stream for the crossing from ignorance to a purer state of being or salvation, or that from the profane to the sacred, is common to Hindus, Jains, Sikhs and Buddhists.<sup>59</sup> The transition is regarded either as a crossing upwards to heaven, usually connected with the image of a ladder (*sopāna*), or as a crossing over to a different realm, linked to the image of a bridge (*setu*).<sup>60</sup> The latter is a recurrent theme in South Asian water architecture, where islands, carrying temples, pavilions and tombs, are frequently linked by bridges to the bank of tanks and lakes. At such sites, the devotee partakes in an actual crossing of water and reaches a sphere which is different from the ordinary world around. The island is an isolated space, embodying a religious ideal of purity, and carrying the primordial divine essence in the form of a temple or image. The same is true for temples or pavilions which are built straight into the water of basins, lakes or rivers, or for islands not connected by bridges, where the crossing has to be done by boat. Places surrounded by water on all sides are considered particularly sacred.<sup>61</sup>

<sup>54</sup> S. M. Bhardwaj, 1983, *Hindu Places of Pilgrimage in India: A Study in Cultural Geography*, p. 95; M. Stutley, 1993, *Hinduism: The Eternal Law*, p. 139.

<sup>55</sup> D. Eck, 1981, "India's Tīrthas: 'Crossings' in Sacred Geography", *History of Religion*, p. 336; M. Eliade, 1987(b), *The Sacred and the Profane: The Nature of Religion*, pp. 20–21.

<sup>56</sup> Eck, 1981, p. 323.

<sup>57</sup> A. W. Entwistle, 1987, *Braj: Centre of Krishna Pilgrimage*, p. 293.

<sup>58</sup> Eck, 1981, p. 335. The term *tīrtha* is also frequently used to describe the sacred milk and water mixture which is poured over the *linga* in temples of Śiva and channelled out of the *vimāna* through a *praṇālī*.

<sup>59</sup> Kinsley, 1987, p. 56.

<sup>60</sup> The Ganges is sometimes referred to as "the flowing ladder to heaven", *svarga-sopāna-sarīrī* (Eck, 1981, p. 325).

<sup>61</sup> J. Pieper, 1979(a), "Water Architecture in Hindu Urban Architecture", *Art and Archaeology Research Papers*, p. 41.

*Tīrthas* are places of pilgrimage to which devotees travel often over hundreds of kilometres because at these places a crossing to a higher sphere may safely be made. The difficulty of the journey (*durlābha*) to reach often remote sites or locations on steep mountains, increases the merit gained by the pilgrims and is part of a self-sacrifice of the pilgrim's soul,<sup>62</sup> an idea which will be discussed more closely in the section on ablutions. Although the ceremonies conducted at sacred *tīrthas* are usually no different from those performed elsewhere, they are regarded as more fruitful and beneficial, because *tīrthas* are imbued with divine energy and the sacred power of the site. Pilgrims attain merit, a higher status in the community, and they become spiritually purified. The merit gained by visiting *tīrthas* and particularly sacred bathing places, is said to be equal to or greater than that achieved by Vedic sacrifices, and pilgrimage can replace other ceremonies and rites of sacrifice.<sup>63</sup> *Daśāśvamedha Ghāt*, the *ghāt* of the ten horse sacrifices, in Benares, is called so after the Vedic sacrifice which is believed to have been conducted at the site by King Divodāsa. Today, a bath at the *ghāt* is considered equally rewarding.<sup>64</sup> Because women and outcasts were not allowed to participate in certain Brahmanical rites and in Vedic sacrifices,<sup>65</sup> pilgrimage and bathing in sacred *tīrthas* opened up new possibilities to these groups of society for acquiring merit. This may also be a reason to account for the many women patrons of water structures, particularly stepwells. The dedication of water structures to the public is an auspicious deed, which was one of only a few means whereby women might acquire religious merit. The movement away from Vedic rituals contributed to the development and importance of the tradition of pilgrimage to sacred *tīrthas* which, today, is one of the most developed expressions of popular religiosity and belief in South Asia. Pilgrimage to sacred *tīrthas* is an important unifying force not only for the people of India, but the whole of South Asia.

In the same way as the Ganges is the prototype of all sacred waters, Benares is regarded as the archetype of the *tīrtha*. It is the final destination where after many lives, final liberation from the circle of rebirth (*saṃsāra*) is gained. There are complex links between the sacred *tīrthas* of India, which are believed to be connected, to exist within each other, and to increase each other's sanctity. Because Benares is the archetypal *tīrtha*, representations of other sacred places and towns have been created at Benares. The northern part of *Daśāśvamedha Ghāt* at Benares for instance is called *Prayāga Ghāt*, the old name of modern Allahabad (*Illāhābād*, *Prayāga*) in Uttar Pradesh, an important *tīrtha* on the Ganges itself. A further *ghāt* takes the name of the sacred mountain *tīrtha*, Lake *Mānasarovar* in Tibet, and a tank in the south of the town is called *Kurukṣetra Tīrtha*,<sup>66</sup> referring to the sacred tank at *Kurukṣetra* (*Kurukṣetra*) in Haryana. At *Pañcagaṅgā Ghāt*, the four invisible rivers *Yamuna*, *Sarasvatī*, *Dhūtpapa* and *Kirana* are believed to merge with the Ganges,<sup>67</sup> making it a particularly sacred place to bathe. To immerse oneself in a sacred river purifies body and soul, but bathing in a sacred confluence is to be immersed in

<sup>62</sup> D. D. Shulman, 1980, *Tamil Temple Myths: Sacrifice and Divine Marriage in the South Indian Siva Tradition*, p. 18.

<sup>63</sup> Entwistle, 1987, p. 293; Eck, 1981, p. 337.

<sup>64</sup> K. K. Klostermaier, 1994, *A Survey of Hinduism*, p. 166; Eck, 1981, p. 338.

<sup>65</sup> Kane, 1974, vol. II, part II, pp. 889, 157 n.

<sup>66</sup> This shallow tank is also known as *Kurukṣetra Kuṇḍa*.

<sup>67</sup> P. Sheshadri, 1925, *Benares*, p. 35; H. Wilson, 1985, *Benares*, p. 22.

several *tīrthas* at the same time, which is even more purifying and powerful. Such places as Allahabad, where the Ganges, the Yamuna and the underground Sarasvati merge, or Trivenī Ghāt at Rishikesh (Ṛṣikeś) in Uttar Pradesh, the confluence of the Ganges with the invisible Yamuna and Sarasvati, are therefore particularly auspicious places. There is also a sense in which there is not only one Benares in India; many places, particularly in the south, partake in the sacredness of the town: Shivakashi (Śivakāśī) in Tamil Nadu, and Shivagange (Śivagaṅge) the 'Dakshina Kashi' (Dakṣiṇā Kāśī) or 'Southern Kashi' near Bangalore in Karnataka, are but two among many southern localities representing the sacredness of Benares.

It is important for the understanding of many water structures, that through legends, images of the river goddess or through special water basins, the river Ganges is believed to be present at other sacred places or water sites. Particularly common is the idea of the 'Pātāla Gaṅgā', the underground or lower Ganges. This phenomenon is based on the belief that the Ganges has subterranean currents running throughout the subcontinent. At certain places, such as an underground cave in Kalinjar Fort, a well in the Kālahastīśvara Temple at Kalahasti or a basin in the fort at Nandi, one can descend to the Ganges, tap it through a well, or bathe in it where it emerges above ground.<sup>68</sup> The same notion arises with other sacred rivers, and a well outside Amarkantak is supposed to provide access to the underground confluence of the Narmada and the Son Rivers. In the following chapters, several examples will be presented where basins constructed in temples or within rivers, which are themselves sacred, are believed to be either permanently or temporarily filled with Ganges water. This does not mean that the sites themselves are not sacred, but rather that they are further purified and sanctified by the emergence or presence of the purest of all rivers.

### *The Siting of Religious Centres*

Because the potency of place is such an important spiritual concept in South Asia, the siting of sacred centres and temples is critically important. Pilgrimage centres often developed around ancient *tīrthas* located at prominent geographical or natural sites. The images and temples set up at a later stage at these places partake in the sacredness of the site and contribute to it, while the sacred site remains the main object of veneration. Temples were not constructed to create a sacred place, but were built on a certain site because the place itself had long been considered holy. Frequently, entire cities developed around sacred localities to cater for the needs of pilgrims and to benefit from the sacredness of the place.

Yet temples and monasteries exist not only at ancient sacred sites, but are present in every modern city or newly established town quarter. Because the presence of water is essential for temple rituals and ablutions, a temple is meant to be located close to a source of water. The ritual need for water is augmented by the belief that gods dwell and pass their time near water, particularly along river banks, and that therefore it is more likely that gods will permanently inhabit temples located close to water. The *Viṣṇudharmottara* says, "In places without tanks, gods are not present. A temple therefore should be built where there is a pond on the left, or in front, not other-

<sup>68</sup> All these places are locally referred to as 'Pātāla Gaṅgās'.

wise.<sup>69</sup> Although there are plenty of examples where large water structures are located to the right or at the back of a temple,<sup>70</sup> there is no temple lacking access to water. The source of water can be a simple draw well or today even a water tap, but many temples are found close to sacred rivers or lakes, or they have large tanks or deep *kuṇḍas* adjacent to them. This fact provides the context in which to view a modern report on the sacred pilgrimage site of Pashupatinath. Owing to the many industries surrounding the Kathmandu Valley which redirect much of the Bagmati's waters for their own purposes, and because of climatic changes, hardly any water remains in the sacred river during the dry season. Therefore, it is the special concern of the religious authorities to ensure at least a minimum flow to guarantee the presence of gods and to heighten the 'spiritual potency' of the place.<sup>71</sup>

#### 4. WATER RITUALS

##### *Concepts of Purity and Pollution*

Concepts of purity and pollution are common to all the world religions, and play an important role in the religions of the Indian subcontinent. Hinduism especially has a highly developed system of relative pollution, which serves as a structuring principle of society. While some pollutions may be due to deliberate acts violating social or religious norms, such as murder or the crossing of caste borders, pollution may also occur accidentally. Unintentional religious pollutions may be caused through bodily functions such as urination, bleeding or death. Since these kinds of pollution cannot be prevented, the main emphasis has been directed towards establishing boundaries to prevent other people from being affected, and towards providing means of subsequent purification.<sup>72</sup> Ritual pollution is also closely associated with social bonding, since one's birth into a certain caste or family determines one's social status and the crossing of social lines is regarded as dangerous and polluting. This category also involves stages of transition, such as interruptions and changes in a person's life, referred to as life crisis events. Complicated purification rites are often associated with these critical rites of passage which demarcate major points of transition such as childbirth, initiation, marriage, and death. It is the idea of crossing and of not being part of any of two fixed categories any longer, which makes such transitions so dangerous and polluting to the persons involved and those associated with them. Rituals following religious pollutions are generally oriented to reinforcing the principles of health and the boundaries of society; they assist individuals to cope with life crises, and to establish a relationship with the sacred.<sup>73</sup> Practically all such rites involve water. Concepts of purity and pollution not only deal

<sup>69</sup> *Viṣṇudharmottara* III, 43.25-31 (S. Kramrisch, 1991, *The Hindu Temple*, p. 5).

<sup>70</sup> There are *kuṇḍas* to the right of the Mallikārjuna Temple at Srisaīlam, and the Navalīṅga Temple at Kukknur (Kukkanūr) in Karnataka. Examples of water structures behind temples are, for example, the *kuṇḍa* behind the Mahādeva Temple at Ittagi (Ittagi) in Karnataka, and the tanks at the back of the Mahākāleśvara Temple at Ujjain (Ujjayni) in Maharashtra, and the Mukteśvara Temple at Bhubaneshwar.

<sup>71</sup> S. R. Tiwari, 1988, *Tiered Temples of Nepal*, p. 62.

<sup>72</sup> Thus since even high caste members cannot escape pollution, a Brahmin householder is obliged to bathe and perform complex purification rituals three times a day.

<sup>73</sup> Preston in Eliade, 1987(a), vol. 12, p. 99.



with physiological and social aspects of life, but also with spiritual pollution and the maintenance of the boundaries of the sacred. The degree of intrinsic pollution of any person makes rites of purification necessary before entering the sacred and therefore pure space of a temple or mosque. The visit of a sacred precinct is a crossing of borders, a transition from the profane to the sacred, which demands purification ritual.

### *Ritual Ablutions*

There are many purifying agents, such as fire, cow's urine,<sup>74</sup> fasting, sexual abstinence and self-mortification. The most efficient ritual means of purification, however, is thought to be running water because it absorbs pollution and carries it away.<sup>75</sup> Considered especially cleansing therefore is the water of rivers and springs which are also believed to have healing, regenerating and rejuvenating properties. But even the running water from a modern tap or the stagnant water of sacred lakes and holy wells is regarded as efficient means of purification. Devotees of all Indian faiths have to be in a ritual state of purity before worship or prayer. Ablution rituals before the visit to a temple, gurdwara (*gurudvārā*, 'the guru's residence') or mosque involve ritual bathing, which can be a total immersion in water, the washing of certain parts of the body (particularly those most exposed to pollution such as the feet), or the sprinkling of water onto the head or body. Such ceremonial washings are not concerned with hygiene, but are symbolic actions which internally prepare the person for the crossing of a border. By being ritually clean, the devotee can come closer to the divine reality, and contact is more easily possible. In purification rituals, the religious boundaries between the domains of purity and pollution are re-established and honoured, and order is reinstated after a period of transition which is regarded as polluting. The newly established norms of purity are essential for a successful encounter with the divine.

In the Hindu versions of the creation of the world, water represents chaos and a formless state of existence because it predates the creation of forms and order. Inasmuch as water dissolves all form, bathing—especially total immersion in water—symbolises a return to the pre-formal. On the human level, the immersion of the body in water is equivalent to personal death, the conscious sacrifice of one's soul, because it means the dissolution of form, a reintegration into the formlessness of pre-existence, and a fusion with the cosmic unity.<sup>76</sup> The subsequent re-immersion from the waters is equivalent of a new birth, in which the old life and all its pollution and sins have been dissolved. As such, what looks from the outside like physical washings really are purifications of the soul. It is not enough to physically participate in the ritual, but people seeking a renewal of their soul will utter prayers to place themselves in the right frame of mind to sacrifice their soul. Ablutions before visiting a temple make the step from the ordinary to the sacred possible, because

<sup>74</sup> All bodily products of cows are regarded as being especially purifying by Hindus. When a house has been polluted by a death, or whenever there is a need for a special act of purification, dung, milk, ghee, curd and urine, all five being products of cows, are mixed and applied to the walls and inhabitants of the house to purify them (Preston in Eliade, 1987(a), vol. 12, p. 96).

<sup>75</sup> Eck, 1993, p. 216.

<sup>76</sup> At a cosmic level, this idea is equivalent to the cataclysm or the great flood, which at the end of a world era destroys and re-absorbs the world before it is created anew out of water (M. Eliade, 1993, *Patterns in Comparative Religion*, p. 194).

they prepare the devotee for the crossing to a higher and purer sphere of consciousness. The person comes thereby in tune with the primordial cosmic order, and conforms to the ritual order of the temple.

The notion that ceremonial washings are followed by new birth explains also the regenerating and rejuvenating properties attributed to water, the belief that contact with it can heal physical illnesses and mental distress, and the view of water as *amṛta*, the elixir of life. Thereby, too, is explained the perceived need for water in funerary rites. Other objects or substances, such as cooking utensils and food, are also purified by sprinkling water onto them, and in some temples the water of a particular well is used to purify offerings before they are handed to the priest. Temple images are bathed (Plate 5), and on certain festival days, they are immersed in the temple tanks or bathed in sacred well water. Through these rituals, the divinities are reborn and invigorated with new life and sacred energy.

As pointed out above, the concepts of purity and pollution are particularly well-developed and refined in Hinduism, and every temple must have a water source. Various religious texts prescribe the ritual of bathing, particularly that in the Ganges, although it hardly differs from the ceremonies carried out at any other river or tank. Water used for ablutions is previously invested with the presence of the Ganges and the other six sacred rivers of India,<sup>77</sup> which at the Ganges is done by putting one's hands into the water and pronouncing certain *mantras*. This is followed by external washings, further *mantras* and gestures, and the greeting of the sun (*sūrya-namaskāra*) and the four cardinal directions. After a series of other preparatory rituals, the believers are ready for taking the bath proper (*snāna*). They stand in the water, turn towards the source and welcome the current of the river, with both hands joined in front of the body, pronouncing the appropriate *mantras* followed by a triple immersion of the entire body.<sup>78</sup> In the first immersion, the believers pronounce a *mantra* through which they try to abandon their physical body (*sthūla śarīra*). During the second immersion, they mentally recite a *mantra* to abandon their subtle body (*sūkṣma*), followed by a third dip during which they visualise themselves as being a *bīja*, a germ or seed. By mentally abandoning their causal bodies (*kāraṇa*), they experience their own death and reintegrate with the world of pre-existence. Stepping out of the water, the sacrificers regain their 'three bodies'.<sup>79</sup> Believers may also take several gulps of water to internally cleanse their bodies (*ācamana*).<sup>80</sup> These ceremonies are frequently followed by rites of libation to one's ancestors (*tarpaṇa*), described in the following section on ancestral rituals.

Muslims too must be in a state of ritual purity before praying or participating in Friday Worship in a mosque, and this involves usually the washing of the face, the hands and the feet (Plates 109–111). If no pure water is available, according to the *Sharī'a*, the divine law, sand or

<sup>77</sup> P. Amado, 1971, "Le Bains dans la Gange: Sa Signification", *Bulletin de l'École Française d'Extrême-Orient*, pp. 197, 200.

<sup>78</sup> *Ibid.*, pp. 200–201.

<sup>79</sup> *Ibid.*, p. 205; Eliade, 1993, pp. 188, 194.

<sup>80</sup> Amado, 1971, p. 202.

dust should be used.<sup>81</sup> Minor ablutions are called *wuḍu* (*wuḍū*), and major ones *ghusl*.<sup>82</sup> The *Shari'a* also points out that ablutions, like other ritual acts, are made valid only by the right intention and concentration on God. The mere physical performance of the rituals without an inner development is worthless.<sup>83</sup> According to the *Ḥadīth*, "Cleanliness is part of the Faith",<sup>84</sup> and this led not only to the construction of ablution tanks and fountains in mosque courtyards, private houses and palaces, but also to the development of elaborate bath houses, the *ḥammāms*. Water imagery is found throughout Islamic literature, particularly in poetry and mythical writings, where water is a symbol of the divine. The water is believed to have been sent by Allāh,<sup>85</sup> and the Prophet is frequently compared to blessed rain or a river flowing into the 'divine ocean of life'.<sup>86</sup> To some extent, this may be a sign of an assimilation of pre-Islamic river cults, but it also expresses the profound importance of water in Islam, where Muslims believe that even the sound of water can revive and heal man.<sup>87</sup> Many mosques were constructed near large tanks, and a small mosque at the Quṭb Shāhī Tombs at Golconda in Andhra Pradesh was constructed over a spring. To those who follow the teachings of Islam, the *Qur'ān* promises a life in paradise with rivers of pure water, milk, wine and honey.<sup>88</sup> Islamic funerary rites involve the offering of *āb-e-zamzam*, water from the sacred well of Zamzam in the precincts of the Great Mosque of Mecca, to the dying.<sup>89</sup>

Sikhs, Jains and Buddhists seem at first glance more critical and even opposed to ritual purification through water and bathing. Guru Nānak<sup>90</sup> wrote in the *Ādī Granth* (*Gurū Granth Sāhib*), the holy book of the Sikhs,

Should a man go to bathe at a place of pilgrimage with the mind of a crook and the body of a thief, his exterior will of course be washed, but inwardly he will be twice as dirty as before. ... Saintly people are pure without such ablutions. (verse 789).<sup>91</sup>

Before this century, many Sikh rituals, particularly those associated with life-cycle rites did, however, demand ablutions involving water, and particularly that of the sacred Ganges. Two weeks after the birth of a baby, for example, the family priest had to sprinkle the members of the household with Ganges water;<sup>92</sup> halfway to the cremation grounds, water was sprinkled on the body of a deceased, the mourners took a purifying bath after the cremation, the bones and ashes of

<sup>81</sup> J. A. Williams (ed.), 1994, *The Word of Islam*, pp. 68, 70. It is interesting to note that *Shari'a* means 'the right way to the water' (Ibid., p. 66).

<sup>82</sup> Welch in J. R. Hinnells (ed.), 1991, *A Handbook of Living Religions*, p. 138.

<sup>83</sup> Williams, 1994, p. 69.

<sup>84</sup> Rötzer in P. D. Couté & J. M. Léger, 1989, *Bénarès: Un voyage d'architecture—An Architectural Voyage*, p. 95.

<sup>85</sup> The *Qur'ān* 6, 99.

<sup>86</sup> Schimmel in Petruccioli, 1985, pp. 6, 8.

<sup>87</sup> Ibid., p. 9.

<sup>88</sup> The *Qur'ān* 20, 72 and 47, 15.

<sup>89</sup> M. Asad, 1988, *Indian Muslim Festivals and Customs*, p. 77.

<sup>90</sup> In a Sikh context, 'guru' is frequently spelled 'gurū'. See for example W. O. Cole & P. S. Sambhi, 1994, *Sikhism*, pp. 44, 68, 116, and Klostermaier, 1994, pp. 46, 485.

<sup>91</sup> Cole & Sambhi, 1994, p. 24.

<sup>92</sup> H. Oberoi, 1995, *The Construction of Religious Boundaries: Culture, Identity and Diversity in the Sikh Tradition*, p. 336.

the dead were either personally brought and immersed in the Ganges, or sent there by the family Brahmin (*brāhmaṇa*), and as part of post-cremation rites (*śrāddha*), rice balls (*piṇḍa*) were immersed in a river.<sup>93</sup> Because many Sikh rites of passage were, however, viewed as too similar to the Hindu equivalents, between 1884 and 1915 several manuals were published describing the proper way for Sikhs to execute these rites.<sup>94</sup> From that time on, the ashes and bones of the dead were not to be immersed in the Ganges any more but in the nearest river, tank or canal, and no *śrāddha* rituals were to be executed. Although importance was removed from the waters of the Ganges, the importance of bathing and of water for funerary and other religious rites continued, and the concepts of purity and pollution, which were regarded as a Hindu influence, have not been eradicated entirely.<sup>95</sup> Sikhs have to bathe and put on clean clothes before their morning prayer or a visit to the temple, and more important ceremonies require a full or so-called 'head-' or 'hair-bath'. There is hardly any gurdwara in India without at least one large ablution tank and further walk-through basins prevent anybody from entering a sacred Sikh temple without having washed at least their feet (Plate 4). The architectural material itself speaks of the importance of water and bathing in Sikhism. Although certain tanks, such as the Amṛt Sarovar at Amritsar (Amṛtasarovar), and the tank at Tarn Taran, both in Punjab, are believed to be especially curative of leprosy, Sikhs do not normally seem to travel to far distant *tīrthas* because the waters there are considered more purifying, but because they are places of religious importance.

Like the Sikhs, the Jains incorporated rituals into their religious ceremonies which were regarded as Hindu-derived. During the medieval period, Jaina writers and mendicants such as Somadeva opposed practices such as ritual bathing and making *śrāddha* offerings to the dead, which were considered alien to the religion and as secular practices.<sup>96</sup> Lay Jains are, however, expected to bathe and put on clean clothes before visiting a temple, in order to show reverence and respect to the images.<sup>97</sup> Also *Śvetāmbara* nuns and monks may wash, but Jaina ascetics are not allowed to bathe in water, a practice regarded as worldly and harmful to organisms living in the water.<sup>98</sup> Jains also use the term *tīrtha* to denote a sacred place, and the Jaina Tīrthaṅkaras are 'fordmakers' who enable others to cross the ocean of rebirth and gain enlightenment. Almost uniformly rejected, however, is the idea that bathing at a sacred *tīrtha* will result in spiritual purity. Nevertheless, the Jains created elaborate water structures at their sacred places of pilgrimage,<sup>99</sup> and many of their temples are located on the banks of rivers, such as those at Ayodhya (Ayodhyā), Benares and Chandrapuri (Candra Purī, Candrāvātī) in Uttar Pradesh, and at Murshidabad in West Bengal. Other Jaina temples were constructed in the centre of tanks and reservoirs, and seem to have been modelled on the concept of the Jalamandir at Pavapuri (Pāvāpurī, Āśāpurī)

<sup>93</sup> Ibid., p. 338–339.

<sup>94</sup> Ibid., p. 339.

<sup>95</sup> Cole in Hinnells, 1991, p. 254.

<sup>96</sup> Carrithers in M. Carrithers & C. Humphrey, 1991, *The Assembly of Listeners: Jains in Society*, pp. 165, 188–189.

<sup>97</sup> J. Laidlaw, 1995, *Riches and Renunciation: Religion, Economy, and Society among the Jains*, p. 271.

<sup>98</sup> P. Dundas, 1992, *The Jains*, pp. 1–2, 141.

<sup>99</sup> Whilst elaborate water tanks are to be found for example in the compounds of the Śītalnātha Temple, the Dādā Gurudeva Temple and the Pārśvanātha Temple, all three in Calcutta (Kalkatā) in West Bengal, simpler water reservoirs are also to be found on the pilgrimage routes to all sacred Jaina mountains.

in Bihar, which marks the spot at which Mahāvīra was cremated. Similar water temples were constructed all over east and central India. Totally surrounded by water and reached by narrow causeways, the water temples seem removed from this world and correspond well to the Jaina ideal of purity and seclusion from earthly life (Plate 129).

There is a general belief that for Buddhists water has no strong religious connotations, and in several passages in Buddhist literature the Buddha or his followers preach against the Hindu belief in the purifying aspects of water. In the Buddhist *Sūtras*, however, the image of water, and particularly that of the lotus pool, is frequently used as a metaphor for the Buddha nature and *nirvāṇa*. Water is an important aspect of Buddhist cosmologies, and in South East Asia especially, large scale architectural projects were constructed with water as a major element in their layout to afford material expression to abstract religious and cosmological visions of the cosmos and paradise. Projects clearly related to the structure of the universe and expressing the importance of water in it, are Borobodur in Java and Neak Pean at Angkor in Cambodia.<sup>100</sup> Water also plays an important role in Buddhist perceptions of time and cyclic world eras, and in *Mahāyāna* Buddhism purification rituals gained a new importance in temple rituals and festivals.<sup>101</sup> Like the followers of all other Indian religions, the Buddhists created technically and artistically impressive water monuments during all periods and in every region of South Asia (Plates 130, 136).

Much of the rejection of water as a purifying element and of Hindu ablution rites by Sikhs, Jains and Buddhist seems to have been based on a simplified view and misunderstanding of Hindu purification rituals. While such rites are frequently portrayed as merely external and physical washings, they actually refer to an inward state of the soul. Purification and liberation only come from wisdom, and in the same way as ceremonial washings form part of purifying pilgrimages, so do the notions of truth, charity, patience, self-control, celibacy and wisdom. All have to be followed to achieve a purification of the heart, a process which may only be enhanced by the sacred power of the Ganges.<sup>102</sup>

#### *Death and Ancestral Rituals*

The most polluting and ritually dangerous of the life crisis events is death. This is not only because it involves contact with a decayed and often sick body, but also because it breaks social bonds and brings chaos and disorder to the wider family or community.<sup>103</sup> Not only the family members who come into direct physical contact with dead bodies, but also those who are merely related to them, have to perform special purification rituals. In most Indian cities the cremation grounds are found outside the densely inhabited area, and the dead have to be brought to the cremation sites on routes which are strictly prescribed by the deceased person's religion and social status, to prevent other people from unnecessarily coming into contact with this major

<sup>100</sup> R. E. Fisher, 1993, *Buddhist Art and Architecture*, pp. 22-23.

<sup>101</sup> For a more detailed discussion of the meaning of water in Buddhism and the Buddhist water architecture of the Kathmandu Valley, please refer to my article 1997(b) "The Lotus Pool: Buddhist Water Sanctuaries in the Kathmandu Valley", *South Asian Studies*, no. 13, pp. 145-159.

<sup>102</sup> Eck, 1981, p. 340.

<sup>103</sup> Preston in Eliade, 1987(a), vol. 12, p. 94.

source of pollution. Only in Benares are the burning grounds located in the centre of the city, because death in Benares leads to salvation.

Since the total immersion or the symbolic sprinkling of water onto a dead body dissolves form and leads to a new beginning, funerary rites involving water are believed to assure a rebirth of the dead.<sup>104</sup> Water is regarded as the primordial substance from which all life evolves and to which it all recedes at the time of death. To remove the ritual pollution of the dead, and to assist them in a new birth, they are cremated on the banks of a river or, if that is not possible, near some other source of water. This is one reason why the banks of rivers were firmly constructed in stone and furnished with steps and cremation platforms. Particularly the Ganges, as the prototype of the sacred waters, plays an important mediating role between this world and that of the dead. Hindus believe that death while being immersed in the Ganges, or sipping Ganges water before dying, will lead to final liberation, a rebirth in heaven without a further return to earth. Final liberation can, however, only be reached through wisdom (*jñāna*),<sup>105</sup> and it is the wisdom a dying person gains while uttering the right *mantras* that liberates the soul. After the cremation, the bones and ashes of the dead are sprinkled into the river, and especially if it is the Ganges, this will safely dissolve and lead the dead to heaven.<sup>106</sup> This belief plays a prominent role in the story of the descent of the Ganges, which was needed to dissolve, purify and liberate the sons of King Sāgara. The safest place to gain liberation from the cycle of rebirth is Benares, which explains the desire of pious Hindus to die at the most sacred of all *tīrthas*; many come to spend their final days or years in the *dharmasālās* (*dharmasālās*) along the sacred river. The traveller Ibn Battūta reported in the fourteenth-century on people voluntarily drowning themselves in the Ganges to reach salvation from the cycle of rebirth,<sup>107</sup> and the ashes of people who died in other parts of India are frequently brought to Benares to be dispersed in the Ganges or some other body of water regarded as especially sacred.

Even if a person's ashes were not sprinkled into the Ganges, almost every pilgrimage to Benares will involve the execution of rites for one's dead ancestors. Some relatives travel to Benares during *pitṛpakṣa*, the 'fortnight of the ancestors' during the month of Āśvina (September–October) to perform the yearly ancestral rituals, called *pitṛtarpaṇa* or *śrāddhayajña*. These rites can be performed at any river, and many tanks or ponds all over India, Nepal and Sri Lanka are used for the ceremonies; but the three northern Indian *tīrthas* Allahabad, Benares, and Gaya (Gāyā, Gayā) in Bihar, referred to as the *tristhalī*, are especially renowned for ancestral rituals. The rites performed at the three sacred places differ from the rituals carried out immediately after death, and are believed to result in the final delivery of the dead to their new state of existence. *Śrāddha* ceremonies last for several days and involve the recital of sacred texts, ablutions and the offering of balls made of the flower of rice or grain (*piṇḍas*) to the ancestors. The *piṇḍas* are thrown into a river or pond and are regarded as food for the deceased.

<sup>104</sup> Eliade, 1993, p. 188.

<sup>105</sup> Eck, 1993, p. 333.

<sup>106</sup> Kinsley, 1987, p. 193; Amado, 1971, p. 206.

<sup>107</sup> Mahajan, 1984, p. 20.



The *Manusmṛiti*, the law of Manu, states that these complicated ancestral rites can be replaced by simple libations with water which are addressed to the dead after a purifying bath.<sup>108</sup> The offering of water to the dead (*tarpaṇa*) aims at stopping their 'thirst', an expression of the fear that they may not have been completely dissolved and extinct.<sup>109</sup> Such libations are carried out in the hope of safely and completely delivering the dead to their final rest, and preventing them from haunting the living as ghosts, *bhūts*. This is also why the dying take a last sip of water, why dead bodies are immersed in water before their cremation, and why their ashes are sprinkled into it. A belief connected especially with the Ganges is that the dead stay as long in heaven as their bones remain in the river's sacred waters. *Tarpaṇa* rituals are usually followed by purifications, such as *ācamana* rites, because even ritual contact with the dead results in impurities.<sup>110</sup>

Cows play an important role in ancestral rituals. On the eleventh day after death, the soul of the deceased is believed to have to cross the mythical Vaitarṇī River of blood dividing our world from the lower regions ruled over by Yama. In order to assist the soul on this dangerous journey a special ritual is performed. Holding on to one another, the chief mourner, a funerary priest, and a cow or calf have to step over a ditch of red coloured water, representing the Vaitarṇī, because the soul of the deceased is believed to cross the river by clinging to a cow's tail. While some relatives bring calves which are subsequently sacrificed, funerary priests working along the sacred waters of India often have their own cows or calves. In a simplified version of the ritual, the cows are merely worshipped.<sup>111</sup>

Frequently, cenotaphs or *chattrīs* have been constructed over sacred spots where important spiritual and worldly leaders have been cremated on the banks of rivers and tanks. Fourteen *chattrīs* along the bank of the Betwa River commemorate the rulers of Orchha (Orchā, Orcchā) (Plate 56), while those of the rulers of Datia line a lake outside Datia (Datiyā, Sonāgir), both in Madhya Pradesh. Examples of elaborate cenotaphs next to artificial water basins may be seen at the Kusum-vāṇ Sarovar, a tank near Govardhan, and at the southern end of the so-called Sāgar Tank, a *kuṇḍa* at Alwar (Alvar) in Rajasthan. The large complexes of cenotaphs at Bara Bagh (Baṛā Bāg) near Jaisalmer and at Mandor (Maṇḍōr) outside Jodhpur (Jōdhpur), both in Rajasthan, have at least small streams which reiterate the importance of water at funerary sites. Where the financial means did not suffice to construct such elaborate structures, simple hero, *satī* or other commemorative stones have been set up lining many rivers, lakes and tanks, such as the Ganges, the lake at Pushkar (Puṣkara, Padmāvati) (Plate 52), and the Sabirna-dha-kā Kuṇḍa at Bundi.

Similarly in Islam, there is a strong relationship between water and death, or more precisely between water and paradise, which is believed to contain streams and pools. In the later Mughal period the tombs of rulers, noblemen and their wives were commonly set in spacious gardens including water courses and pools. Such arrangements express the belief that the dead person has been reborn in paradise. Islamic tombs were also set on islands in water tanks, such as Sher Shāh

<sup>108</sup> *Manusmṛiti* III. 283 (Amado, 1971, p. 206).

<sup>109</sup> Note also that in Islamic rites holy water from the spring in Mecca is given to the dying to stop their thirst (Sharma, 1988, p. 77).

<sup>110</sup> Amado, 1971, p. 208.

<sup>111</sup> J. P. Parry, 1994, *Death in Banaras*, p. 223; Gutschow & Michaels, 1993, p. 199.

Sūr's tomb at Sasaram (Sasarām) in Bihar, and constructed along rivers, such as the tomb of Abū'l Wahāb (Abd al-Wahhāb) at the Tungabhadra River at Kurnool in Andhra Pradesh. Many simpler Muslim graves are also found next to water, such as those next to the Mānasarovar Tank at Viramgam in Gujarat, and the grave adjacent to the Bīja Maṇḍal Bāvlī, a stepwell at Vidisha (Vidiśā, Bhilsa) in Madhya Pradesh. Elaborate mortuary baths were constructed for the washing and preparation of the royal and noble dead before their entombment.

### *Bathing Festivals*

While bathing in any river, lake or tank is always considered purifying, certain days or periods, predominantly due to favourable constellations of the stars, are considered most auspicious and effective for ritual bathing. During such periods, many people will try to take a purifying bath at a particularly important and sacred *tīrtha*, leading at times to the gathering of thousands of people at religious fairs called *melās* or *parvas*. Such fairs are for example held during the solar and lunar eclipses at Kurukshetra, when the invisible Sarasvati River is believed to fill the tank,<sup>112</sup> during October–November at Pushkar, and during Vaiśākha (April–May) at the Pool of Immortality at the Golden Temple at Amritsar.

North India's largest and most important fair is the Kumbha Melā, the fair of the sacred pot. The tradition is based on the story of the churning of the Milky Ocean, when the gods (*devas*) and the demons (*asuras*) were churning the cosmic ocean to extract the elixir of life. When the precious substance was received first the *asuras* got hold of the pot and then, depending on the version, either Indra's son Garuḍa, or one of the gods who took the shape of a bird, usually a crow, saved the pot and flew away with it. On his flight from the Milky Ocean to heaven, he rested four times and put the pot on the earth, each time spilling a little bit of the life-giving elixir. According to different versions, drops of *amṛta* fell from the pot, or the pot itself fell, onto four places in northern India during the flight, sanctifying them forever. The four places are modern Allahabad, known as Prayag, Hardwar, where the Ganges breaks out of the mountains into the Indian plain, Nasik (Nāsik, Nāśik) on the Godavari in Maharashtra, and Ujjain (Ujjaynī) on the Sipra in Madhya Pradesh.<sup>113</sup> Because the flight took twelve days, and each day equals one year on earth,<sup>114</sup> the Kumbha Melā is held every twelve years in turn at one of the four places. The *melā* at Allahabad ranks highest amongst them, Hardwar second, and Ujjain third. Every six years, an intermediate Ardha Kumbha Melā or simply Ardha Melā (half-full pot fair) is held at Allahabad and Hardwar. Every year during the month of Māgh (January–February), a riverside fair called the Māgh Melā takes place at each of the four sites. Māgh Melās are also held at other places, such as Gangasagar where the Ganges enters the Bay of Bengal and where, according to legend, the 60,000 sons of King Sāgara were burned and eventually liberated by the Ganges. While the fair at Gangasagar, usually held in mid-January, lasts only one or two days, at Allahabad thousands of people bathe for an entire month in the sacred confluence.

<sup>112</sup> P. Thomas, 1989, *Festivals and Holidays of India*, p. 21.

<sup>113</sup> At Ujjain and Nasik, the fair is locally known as Simhastha (S. Rai, 1993, *Kumbh Mela: History & Religion, Astronomy & Cosmobiology*, p. 17).

<sup>114</sup> Bonn in Frey & Bonn, 1991, p. 147.

The south Indian equivalent of the northern Kumbha Melā and its related fairs is the Mahāmakham festival (Mahāmakhamana Parva). While people gather every year during the month of Kumbha (February–March) for a bathing festival in the Mahāmakham Tank at Kumbakonam (Kumbhakōṇam) in Tamil Nadu, a great fair is held only once every twelve years. According to the *Sthāla Purāṇa* of Kumbakonam, Brahmā collected the essence of all India's sacred waters and mixed it with *amṛta* in a pot which was kept on Mount Meru. During a great deluge, when the world was destroyed, the pot floated on the cosmic waters; when the water subsided, it settled at Kumbakonam. The pot broke and the elixir gathered in a depression which was later constructed in stone and furnished with steps to create the Mahāmakham Tank.<sup>115</sup> Bathing in the sacred tank is considered equivalent to immersing oneself in all of India's sacred *tīrthas* at once. Bathing during the Kumbha Melā is considered even more purifying because on this occasion, an underground current of the Ganges is believed to flow into the tank.<sup>116</sup> A further related *melā* is the Puṣkaram Festival, held every twelve years at Rajahmundry (Rājahmudrī) on the bank of the Godavari in Andhra Pradesh.<sup>117</sup>

## 5. WATER-RELATED BEINGS AND GODS

### *Symbols and Animals associated with Water*

References to aquatic cosmogonies and water-related motifs are found not only in connection with water architecture, but in religious and palace architecture and in the decorative arts. A common South Asian symbol of water and its aspects of fertility are water pots or vessels known as *kalaśa*, *ghaṭa* or *kumbha*; filled with water (*pūrṇa kalaśa*) they are auspicious symbols. In temple reliefs, plants and flowers are shown growing out of pots representing the source of life. Similar growth can also be shown originating from the mouth of a *makara*, a mythical sea animal (Plates 48), or the mouth or navel of a *yakṣa* or gnomon, a further symbol of growth and fecundity.

Another water related image is the lotus (*padma*). Lotus flowers, leaves and rosettes commonly adorn tanks, *kuṇḍas*, wells and pleasure pools of all periods and religious denominations, and water structures have been built on lotus plans (Plate 46). Because lotuses grow out of water, they are closely associated with its creative and life-giving qualities, and with the purity of water. Hence deities are frequently supported by lotus pedestals. The opening of the lotus flower is an image for the spread of creation from a central point, and in various stories of the cosmogony a lotus is the foundation and support of the world. Also closely related to water is the symbol of the spiral; water channels shaped as spirals or labyrinths in Indian water architecture directly combine the symbol with the element it represents (Plate 40).<sup>118</sup>

Many animals, real and imaginary, are connected with water. These animals are usually believed to be born from the waters, to represent the primordial or divine essence concentrated in

<sup>115</sup> S. M. N. Sastri, 1988, *Hindu Feasts. Fasts and Ceremonies*, pp. 69–70.

<sup>116</sup> *Ibid.*, pp. 72, 75.

<sup>117</sup> *Ibid.*, p. 77; Valliappa, 1992, p. 30.

<sup>118</sup> Such water spirals are discussed at the end of Chapter Seven.

them, and to have the power to regulate the waters. Probably most closely related to water are fish, which cannot survive without it, and whose representation indirectly evokes the presence of water. Fish are frequently carved on the walls or pillars surrounding water structures, as may be seen in the tanks in the first and second enclosures of the Aruṇācaleśvara Temple at Tiruvannamalai (Tiruvannāmalai) in Tamil Nadu, and in the *kuṇḍa* in front of the Rāmacandra Temple at Vijayanagara. Whilst most fish are highly stylised and simplified, those flanking the central steps on the western side of the Teppakuḷam at Madurai are unusual for their large size and elaboration. Carvings may also be seen on platforms supporting water pavilions, two examples of which are found at Vijayanagara. The first is located in the centre of the ceremonial tank belonging to the Kṛṣṇa Temple, and the second is believed to have carried a water pavilion in the so-called Zenānā Enclosure.<sup>119</sup> Part of the first arrangement is a scene where a large fish swallows a smaller one, which may be a visual representation of the political theory of *matsya-nyāya*, the law of the fishes, in which it was the duty of an Indian ruler to prevent "larger fish from eating smaller ones".

Particularly interesting, however, are representations of fish on temple buildings not obviously connected with water. In central and southern India, they are frequently found on or adjacent to temple gateways (*gopuras*), as for example on the inside of the eastern *gopura* of the Kṛṣṇa Temple at Vijayanagara, on the front of the eastern *gopura* of the Temple at Guruvayur (Gurupavanapurā) in Kerala, and adjacent to the first *gopura* on top of the hill at Sravana Belgola (Śravaṇa Belgoḷā) in Karnataka. The fish can be up to two metres long, are carved in high relief, and are clearly differentiated from the Pāṇḍyan emblem which comprises two fish and a staff, which also sometimes adorn *gopuras*, as for example those at the Raṅganātha Temple at Srirangam (Śrīraṅgam) in Tamil Nadu. Fish were also carved onto the ceiling of the closed pavilion (*maṇḍapa*) of the Bṛhadiśvara Temple at Gangaikondacholapuram (Gaṅgaikoṇḍaḥapuram) in Tamil Nadu, on the inside of the first temple enclosure on top of the hill at Sravana Belgola, and on the inside of the enclosure wall of the Malyavata Raghunātha Temple at Vijayanagara. Large fish also adorn the columns supporting the roof of the circumambulation path (*pradakṣiṇā-patha*) around the Sundareśvara Shrine at Madurai. The fish carvings are therefore either found at thresholds, thoroughfares or transitional parts of temple complexes, such as *gopuras* or *maṇḍapas*, or in the most sacred precinct, such as on the inner enclosure wall or the *pradakṣiṇā-patha*. Therefore, it may be assumed that like the depictions of the river goddesses Gaṅgā and Yamunā flanking temple doorways, fish which stand in close relationship to the sacred waters have a purifying and guarding significance. Visitors to a temple should have conducted proper ablutions to be in a ritually pure state before entering, and the fish may remind them that they are embarking on a fording. Particularly fish carved on the inside of *gopuras* and closed *maṇḍapas* through which the devotees pass convey the feeling of an underwater passage into the temple, which dissolves form and life, and results in a new birth in the pure environment of the temple. Close to the centre of the temple, the presence of fish may also visualise the fact that one has entered a different and purer sphere in which an encounter with the cosmic unity may be possible.

<sup>119</sup> *Zenānā* is the Indian way of spelling the Arabic word *zanāna*.

Since most carvings of fish on temple elements are found on later structures, dating from the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries,<sup>120</sup> and considering that total immersions of the body or more extensive bathing rituals at temple sites seem at least in northern India to have diminished at many temple sites, it may also be suggested that the fish decorations are representative of a stage of religious development where people are still aware of the religious importance of ritual bathing, but where the custom has become more simplified and abstract. Full immersions of the body have frequently been replaced by the ritual sprinkling of water, and by representations of water-related fish.

Amphibian animals such as frogs, turtles (or tortoises), snakes, elephants, crocodiles, and the mythical *makara* are also closely associated with the waters. Frogs are believed to have cooling qualities and are therefore frequently employed in rituals.<sup>121</sup> They are invoked to send rain and are associated with water structures, where they may adorn water spouts, and are intended to guarantee a regular water supply. More frequently associated with water architecture are representations of turtles. A *kuṇḍa* in turtle shape is part of the Aśvamedha Complex at Nagarjunakonda (Nāgārjunakoṇḍa) in Andhra Pradesh, and depictions of turtles are commonly found adorning the walls of tanks and *kuṇḍas*. Examples may be seen in the *kuṇḍa* in the village of Kamalapuram near Vijayanagara, around the tank of the Mahākāleśvara Temple at Ujjain, and near the sluice at the large tank of the Sarkej Rauzā<sup>122</sup> outside Ahmedabad. Sculptural representations of turtles are also frequently found in connection with shrines and temples. The turtles vary between about twenty and thirty centimetres and are usually made of stone, but also brass sculptures exist, as for example at Pandharpur in Maharashtra. They face the entrance to a temple or shrine, as they do at the Viṭhobā Temple at Pandharpur, a side shrine at the Mūl Dvārakā Temple at Visavada (Vīsavāḍa) in Gujarat, and on top of Brahmagiri at the source of the Godavari (Plate 50). At other times, they may indicate the direction towards an important tank or temple. An example of this may be seen half way up Brahmagiri at Trimbak. In one version of the cosmogony, it is Prajāpati in the shape of a turtle who creates the world, and turtles are seen as an image of the cosmos with the lower part representing the earth, and the upper part the vault of heaven. In the story of the churning of the cosmic ocean, Viṣṇu in his turtle *avatāra* (*kūrma*) supported Mount Maṇḍara on his back, and the entire cosmos is believed to be upheld by a turtle.<sup>123</sup> The association of support and steadiness with turtles found visual expression particularly in Kerala and Nepal, where turtle sculptures are frequently employed as the foundation of pillars, *dhvaja* and *dīpa stambhas*.

A particularly important role is played by snakes (*nāgas*). Carvings of snakes frequently adorn the sides or steps of water structures, as for example those carved on the steps on either side of the risalit<sup>124</sup> in the *kuṇḍa* at Kamalapuram near Vijayanagara. In Nepal, they commonly adorn the top of water spouts. While many representations are true to nature, others depict the *nāgas* as semi-

<sup>120</sup> Only the temple at Gangaikondacholapuram, dating from the mid-11th century, is earlier.

<sup>121</sup> Keith, 1925, pp. 142, 194.

<sup>122</sup> Rauzā is the accepted Hindi spelling of the originally Arabic word *rauza*.

<sup>123</sup> A representation of this story can be seen on the Kālikā Mātā Temple in Chitorgarh.

<sup>124</sup> For a definition and discussion of risalits, see Chapter Five 'Kūṇḍas'.



divine beings, half-snake, half-human. Many of them are regarded as subsidiary deities or attendants to more important gods, and are believed to dwell in water regulated by them. Snakes are therefore regularly propitiated and worshipped to ensure the advent of a good monsoon at the right time. The Nāgapañcamī Festival, held in the Hindu month of Śrāvaṇa (July–August), is only one example of the veneration of snakes. The names of many water structures, as for example the Nāga Kūpa in Benares, refer to snakes who are believed to inhabit them, or to carvings of snakes on their walls, as for instance the large multi-hooded cobra carved on the rock face adjacent to the Nāga Pokuna at Mihintale in Sri Lanka. Stones with snake carvings, so called *nāga-kals*, are frequently found next to tanks, *kuṇḍas* and rivers (Plate 51), and also under trees, particularly in eastern, central and southern India, which are regions with strong traditions in snake worship. In Sri Lanka, *nāga-kals* are also commonly employed for the protection of the dams and sluices of large reservoirs. These snakes are symbolic representations of Mucalinda,<sup>125</sup> and are employed as guardians and protectors of the reservoirs and the waters in general. In Nepal, representations of snakes are also frequently found as balustrades encircling water structures, as for example around the royal baths in Bhaktapur (Bhādgāon) and Patan (Pāṭan) (Plate 37), and in the centre of tanks and lakes in the form of snake poles, the *nāgakaṣṭhas* (*nāgadhvajās*). Plain pillars are also found in eastern and western India, where they are driven into the centre of tanks as part of consecration rituals.<sup>126</sup> They represent the *axis mundi* and the residence of the *nāgas* who rule over the water structure.<sup>127</sup> Snakes also have negative connotations because they live in the earth where they guard treasures, and are as such also associated with the underworld and death.<sup>128</sup>

While frogs, turtles and snakes are often carved onto the walls or other parts of water structures, elephants, crocodiles and *makaras* are more typically fashioned to form water spouts. Water spouts in the shape of elephants are mainly found in what is today the modern state of Karnataka, at places such as Vijayanagara and Belur (Belūr, Bailūr). Crocodile spouts may be found in connection with water structures, such as the Teppakuḷam at Madurai (Plate 49), although they are more typical of *prañālī* spouts associated with temples, especially in Orissa. Most typical of water architecture are spouts in the shape of cow heads, discussed above, and *makaras*. Because the *makara* is the vehicle (*vāhana*) of the river goddess Gaṅgā, water pouring out of the mouth of a *makara* spout is generally equated with Ganges water. In Nepal, this link is further reinforced by depictions of the sage Bhagīratha underneath the spouts. Frequently, spouts are made up of a telescoping series of animals emerging from one another's mouths, representing the abundance of creation (Plate 38).

Water is not only associated with positive and life-giving qualities: in heavy rains, storms and floods, it can be destructive and threatening, and is regarded as a punishment of the gods. This expresses the ambivalence of the sacred which both creates and destroys, and which is powerful and unpredictable.<sup>129</sup> Also the hostile powers of water have been represented in water spouts in

<sup>125</sup> Brohier, 1965, p. 5.

<sup>126</sup> Jain-Neubauer, 1981, p. 9.

<sup>127</sup> Rötzer in Couté & Léger, 1989, p. 92.

<sup>128</sup> W. O'Flaherty, 1973, *Asceticism and Eroticism in the Mythology of Śiva*, p. 26.

<sup>129</sup> Rudhardt in Eliade, 1987(a), vol. 15, pp. 356–357.



the shape of monstrous mythical creatures. A further reason for water spouts in the shape of monsters may be the belief that the waters of life, which are *amṛta*, are difficult to reach and obtain, and that gaining enlightenment is about struggle and sacrifice. Therefore, the sacred waters are believed to be guarded by demonic creatures<sup>130</sup> which have frequently been given artistic shape in imaginative water spouts as may be seen in the spout of the Hema Puṣkariṇī of the Kūṭal Aḷakar Temple at Madurai, or the lion spouts of the Siṃha Pokuna at Mihintale.<sup>131</sup> Nepal, which has particularly many carved water spouts surviving *in situ* has examples of spouts in such monstrous shapes in the bathing tank in Konti in Patan and in the basin of the Navadurgā Temple at Pashupatinath. The largest and probably also most varied and imaginative spouts adorn the western side of the Teppakuḷam at Madurai, and incorporate gnomons, crocodiles, fish and fantastic creatures into their designs. Water spouts are found as inlets into tanks and pleasure pools, as *prañālīs* emerging from Hindu temples, and at the edge of terraces supporting temples and stupas, to carry off rain water.

Birds such as geese, swans and peacocks are also associated with water. Their images frequently adorn water structures or are incorporated in the design as spouts. Geese may be linked to Brahmā's *vāhana*, the *haṃsa*, which is either translated as goose or swan.<sup>132</sup> *Haṃsas* are also the *vāhanas* of Sarasvatī, Candra and Varuṇa, and the peacock is the vehicle of Kārttikeya. Geese and swans are symbols of spiritual transcendence and purity, and are seen as the creative principle.<sup>133</sup> In the same way as swans and geese are related to the lotus seat of deities, and suggests their purity and aloofness, rows of water birds can replace a lotus moulding running around a water basin, and express the purity and sacredness of the water contained.

#### Water Divinities

Water may be viewed as the abode of sacred powers and gods, or may itself be regarded as being divine and an object of worship, and frequently both versions coexist. To represent the divine powers in water, religious images were frequently placed in tanks and rivers, such as a painted stone in the Betwa River at Orchha which is venerated as the river god, a seated image of Śiva in the Kaveri at Paschimawahini (Paschemavāhini) in Karnataka (Plate 55), or an image of Sūrya in one of the four tanks at Shesh Narayan (Śeṣa Nārāyaṇ) in Nepal. Images carved on rock faces of tanks, such as the cobra of the Nāg Pokuna at Mihintale, or the large carving of Kāl Bhairava seeming to emerge from a small tank near the Nīlakaṇṭha Temple in Kalinjar Fort, over the surface of which runs the water of a spring, are even clearer in their message. But iconic images representing the divine powers of the waters are not obligatory; the element water is also worshipped directly. This has already been described in connection with the Ganges, and further

<sup>130</sup> Eliade, 1993, p. 193.

<sup>131</sup> The presence of lion sculptures in the Siṃha Pokuna may also be related to the royal nature of lions.

<sup>132</sup> Although swans are not indigenous to or believed to have inhabited India during the early period, W. Doninger (in S. Sneed (ed.), 1989, *Animals in Four Worlds: Sculpture from India*, p. 16) and T. A. G. Rao (1993, *Elements of Hindu Iconography*, vol. II, part 2, p. 503) translate *haṃsa* as swan.

<sup>133</sup> E. Schleberger, 1986, *Die indische Götterwelt: Gestalt, Ausdruck und Sinnbild. Ein Handbuch der hinduistischen Ikonographie*, p. 193.

examples will be encountered in the following chapters, the most striking example being probably wells located in the *garbhagṛha* of well-temples, which developed alongside temples in which anthropomorphic images of river goddesses or water gods are worshipped. As such, divine associations with water exist on various levels.

A group of water divinities already mentioned in the section on rivers is river goddesses. Because of their purifying aspects and their association with *Idā* and *Piṅgalā*, the two major 'channels' (*nāḍīs*) in the human body, the river goddesses *Gaṅgā* and *Yamunā* have been depicted on either side of temple doorways, since the fifth century AD.<sup>134</sup> Entire temples indeed have been built for the worship of the river goddesses, like the one in the north-western corner of the Kailāsa Temple complex (cave No. 16) at Ellora, housing *Sarasvatī*, *Gaṅgā* and *Yamunā*, or the many shrines dedicated to separate river goddesses. It is surprising that while so many temples which have no direct cultic link to water were set into tanks or on islands, the large *Gaṅgā* Mandir at Bharatpur (Bhāratpur)<sup>135</sup> in Rajasthan, has no literal architectural water connection. Images of *Gaṅgā* Devī are frequently found next to tanks, as for example next to the *Mārkaṇḍeśvara* Tank at Puri (Pūrī) in Orissa, or the *Mallikār* Guṇḍam well (also called *Manohara* Guṇḍam)<sup>136</sup> in the compound of the *Mallikārjuna* Temple at Srisaīlam. Such images invoke the presence of the sacred river Ganges at a water place far away from its actual course, and provide the opportunity to worship *Gaṅgā* Devī in other parts of the subcontinent. It is interesting that at Benares, where no images of *Gaṅgā* would have been needed because there the sacred river itself can be worshipped, numerous shrines with anthropomorphic images of *Gaṅgā* nevertheless line the *ghāṭs* and alleys leading to the river (Plate 8). The same phenomenon is encountered at the source of the Godavari on Brahmagiri, where, next to the actual source in a rock cleft, a personified image of the goddess *Godāvarī* is worshipped in a small shrine. The worship of an abstract element or actual river may be less easily comprehensible to some people than the worship of iconic deities, so common and widespread over the whole of South Asia.

In the iconography of the river and mother goddesses many of the symbols, animals and mythical creatures associated with the sacred waters, discussed above, are re-encountered. The *vāhana* of *Gaṅgā* is usually the *makara* of *Yamunā* the tortoise, and of *Sarasvatī* the peacock, goose or swan, while all of them may also be represented standing on a fish or lotus. More important than the connection with a specific animal or emblem seems to be the association with a water-related animal or plant in general, which expresses spiritual purity and elevates the goddess from the ordinary world. Originally, *Sarasvatī* seems to have been connected with the goose because initially, she was regarded as *Brahmā*'s first wife (later on as *Viṣṇu*'s), and was herself often called *Brahmānī*. It is interesting to note that in popular prints of the goddess, she may either be represented with a peacock, with a goose or swan, or with both animals simultaneously. While in some cases it may be possible that the swans really are beautified geese, in others such as the life-size sculpture of *Sarasvatī* in Chyāsal Hiṭī in Patan, Nepal, the long swan

<sup>134</sup> H. Stietencron, 1972, *Gaṅgā and Yamunā: Zur symbolischen Bedeutung der Flußgöttinnen an indischen Tempeln*, p. 103.

<sup>135</sup> Bhāratpur is also frequently spelled with a short 'a' (Bharatpur).

<sup>136</sup> The term *guṇḍam* for a water basin probably derives from *kuṇḍa*.

neck is unmistakable.<sup>137</sup> Gaṅgā and Yamunā are normally represented carrying a water pot, a fly whisk (*cāmara*) and a lotus, while in some representations Gaṅgā carries a plate of food. Sarasvatī is easily distinguished from them by holding a *vīṇā*, a book and a string of prayer beads (*akṣamālā*).

Among the male gods associated with water, Viṣṇu holds a prominent position. This importance may be derived from his role as the preserver of life, and he is closely connected with several versions of aquatic cosmogonies. As Viṣṇu Nārāyaṇa, he is shown floating on the cosmic ocean between two world eras, and he has several water-related incarnations, the fish (*matsya*) who saves Manu from the deluge, the tortoise (*kūrma*), in which form he assists the churning of the Milky Ocean, and the boar (*varāha*), as which he dives into the sea to rescue Bhū Devī. Sculptural representations of Viṣṇu in connection with water are typical especially of Nepal, and most *dhārās*, the local form of deep stepped basin, contain at least one image of the god, either free standing or placed in a niche. Sculptures of Viṣṇu are also connected with basins and wells all over India.

Śiva too is commonly associated with water architecture, and although anthropomorphic images of the god, his consort and Nandi are not uncommon (Plate 232), there are more representations of his phallic emblem the *liṅga*. These can be carved reliefs of *liṅgas* or sculpted three-dimensional versions placed in the centre or a corner of tanks and along rivers and larger reservoirs. It is interesting to observe that Buddhist stupas may be found in the same position (Plate 53). The *liṅga* is ritually hot and closely associated with the female and cooling element water. The unification of the two polar opposites is considered to create cosmic order and harmony. Śiva's emblem, the *triśūla* is frequently found in a water context.

A further male god associated with the waters is the Vedic God Varuṇa. During the pre-Vedic and the Vedic period, he was connected both with the sun (which was believed to be his eye)<sup>138</sup> and the waters. He was the leader of the *asuras*, the guardian of the cosmic law, and belonged to the powerful triad of Varuṇa, Indra and Agni, the three main gods of the period. His son is Soma, who is equated with *amṛta* and the moon, both again linked to water. Varuṇa was regarded as the guardian of cosmic and ethical order (*ṛta* and *dharma*), and as such closely related to worldly kings who were to enforce the sacred laws of Varuṇa. Except for the fact that Varuṇa is still the guardian (*dikpāla*) of the western direction and the lord of the water, he lost most of his importance at the end of the Vedic period. As god of the waters, the ocean, and in the south of India, also of rain,<sup>139</sup> his *vāhana* also is the *makara* or a chariot drawn by four or seven geese (*haṃsas*), and in rare cases also a fish or swan. He is identified by a lasso (*pāśa*), and attributes of fertility such as a lotus (*padma*), a shell (*śaṅkha*), and a vessel containing gems (*ratna-pātra*).<sup>140</sup> In sculptural representations, the river goddesses Gaṅgā and Yamunā are frequently depicted standing on his right and left sides respectively. Although images of Varuṇa are relatively rare in water structures,

<sup>137</sup> More research would be needed to outline the modification of geese or to trace the introduction of swans into the visual arts in India which would, however, go beyond this study.

<sup>138</sup> Schleberger, 1986, p. 149.

<sup>139</sup> A. & P. Keilhauer, 1990, *Die Bildersprache des Hinduismus: Die indische Götterwelt und ihre Symbolik*, p. 224.

<sup>140</sup> Rao, 1993, vol. II, part 2, p. 530.

shrines adjacent to water architecture, or for example the Varuṇa temple set into the waters of the Naval Sāgar at Bundi, are more typical. As part of the consecration ceremonies of water structures, images of Varuṇa are frequently immersed in their waters.<sup>141</sup>

Further Vedic gods who are more frequently depicted in sculptural panels contained in water structures, are the sun god, Sūrya, and the god of fire and the sun, Agni. Both are believed to have been born from the waters, and to return to it at night, when the sun sets. There are many examples of Sūrya temples in front of which lie tanks and deep *kundās*, as at Gwalior, Delhi (Dehlī, Dillī), Kapadvanj (Kāpaḍvañj) in Gujarat, and Modhera. Additionally, one also finds depictions of the sun and moon, and of anthropomorphic images of the sun god in water structures. Although some other gods, such as Indra, the bringer of rain, and Kubera, the guardian of wealth, are closely connected with the waters in religious texts, they are not typical of water architecture.

The central importance of water for life, coupled with the religious tradition associated with the purity of body and spirit through ritual washings and immersions in water, led to the construction of steps along rivers, and of tanks, *kundās* and wells all over South Asia, to collect and preserve the divine waters, and to make them accessible to the people. These technically and aesthetically impressive structures are important for three reasons. First, they represent the technical achievement of engineers and agricultural specialists who manage water in a region with extreme changes of climate. Secondly, they are the product of the creative minds of gifted artists, and thirdly, they signify the primary significance of water in the religious traditions of South Asia. In this context, water is believed to be the source of creation, the abode of gods and spirits, and a manifestation of the divine. These religious aspects, which are described in religious texts and enacted in rituals, have been given permanent visual shape in countless water structures and images associated with them found in every, even the most remote, part of South Asia. The water structures are visual representations of religious beliefs, whose artistic forms are comprehensible to all the people of South Asia, despite differences in language, caste and the ability to read.

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<sup>141</sup> Jain-Neubauer, 1981, p. 8.